Has WAR Changed MLB MVP Voting?

A preliminary analysis of MVP voting from 1980–2025

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Research question

Testing whether MVP results have become more aligned with comprehensive player value

How has the rise of WAR changed MLB MVP voting?

- Hypothesis: as WAR became more prominent in baseball analysis, MVP voting became more consistent with WAR.
- Important limitation: the analysis can show alignment over time, but it cannot by itself prove that WAR caused voters to change.
- 2020 is excluded from season-comparison analyses because the MLB regular season was shortened.

Data and approach

1980–2025
MVP voting seasons

AL + NL
Separate league races

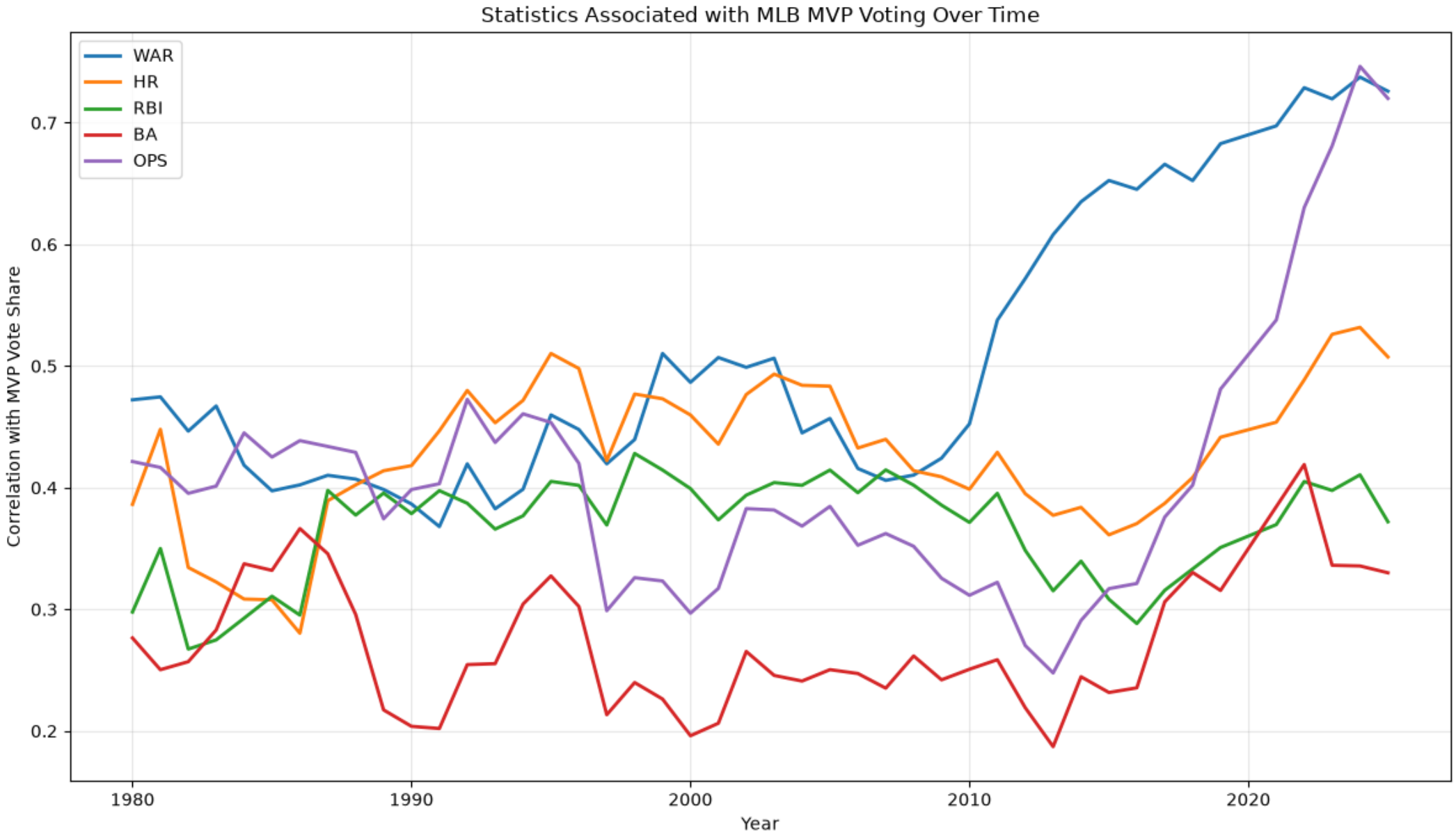
Vote Share
Voting outcome

WAR + 4
WAR, HR, RBI, BA, OPS

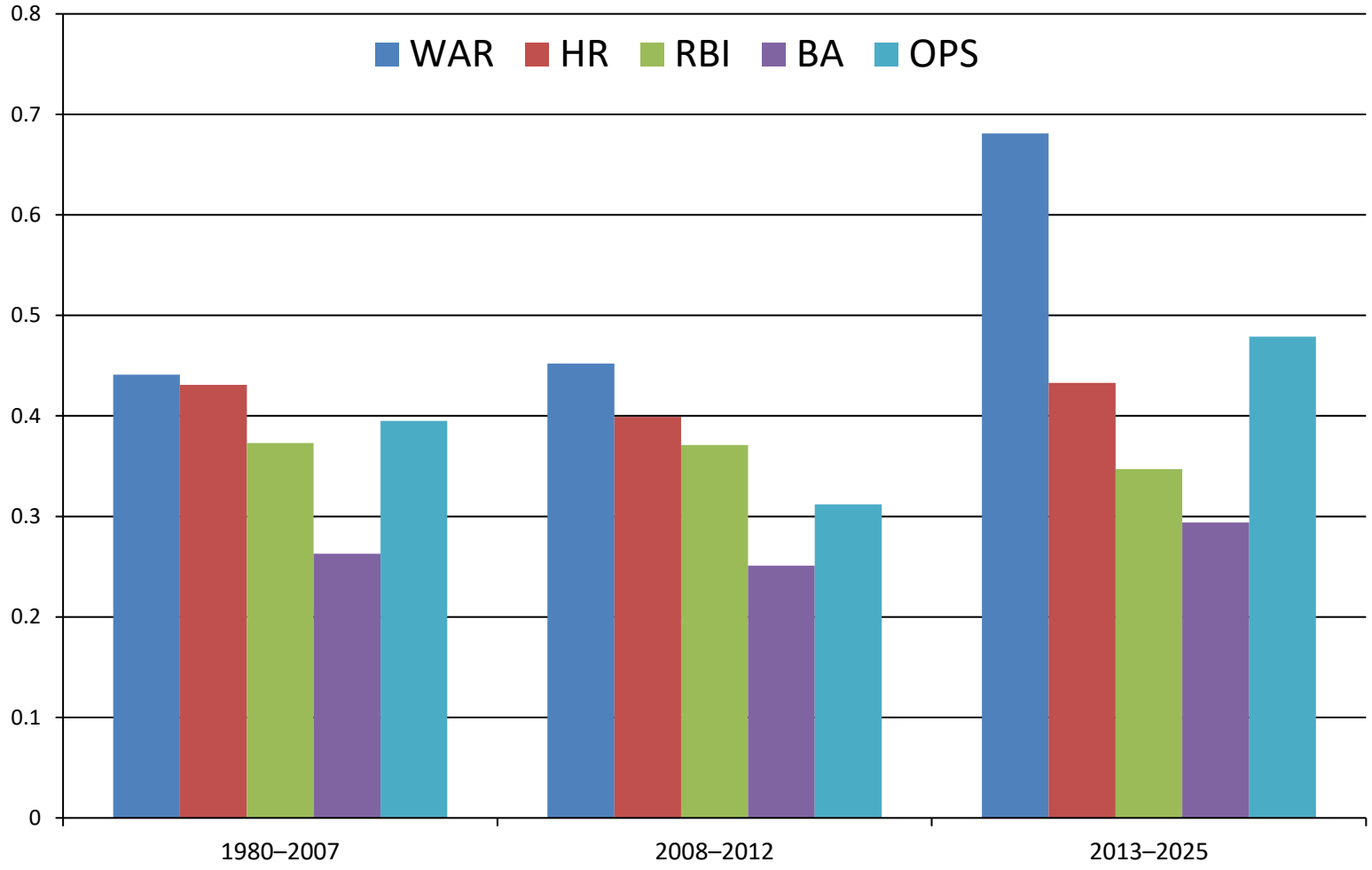
- Historical MVP voting tables were collected into one player-level dataset.
- For each league-season, I calculated the correlation between each statistic and MVP vote share.
- I also compared the MVP winner's WAR with the highest WAR among players receiving MVP votes.

WAR alignment rises sharply in the modern era

5-year rolling average of within-race correlations with MVP vote share



Era comparison: WAR shows the largest shift



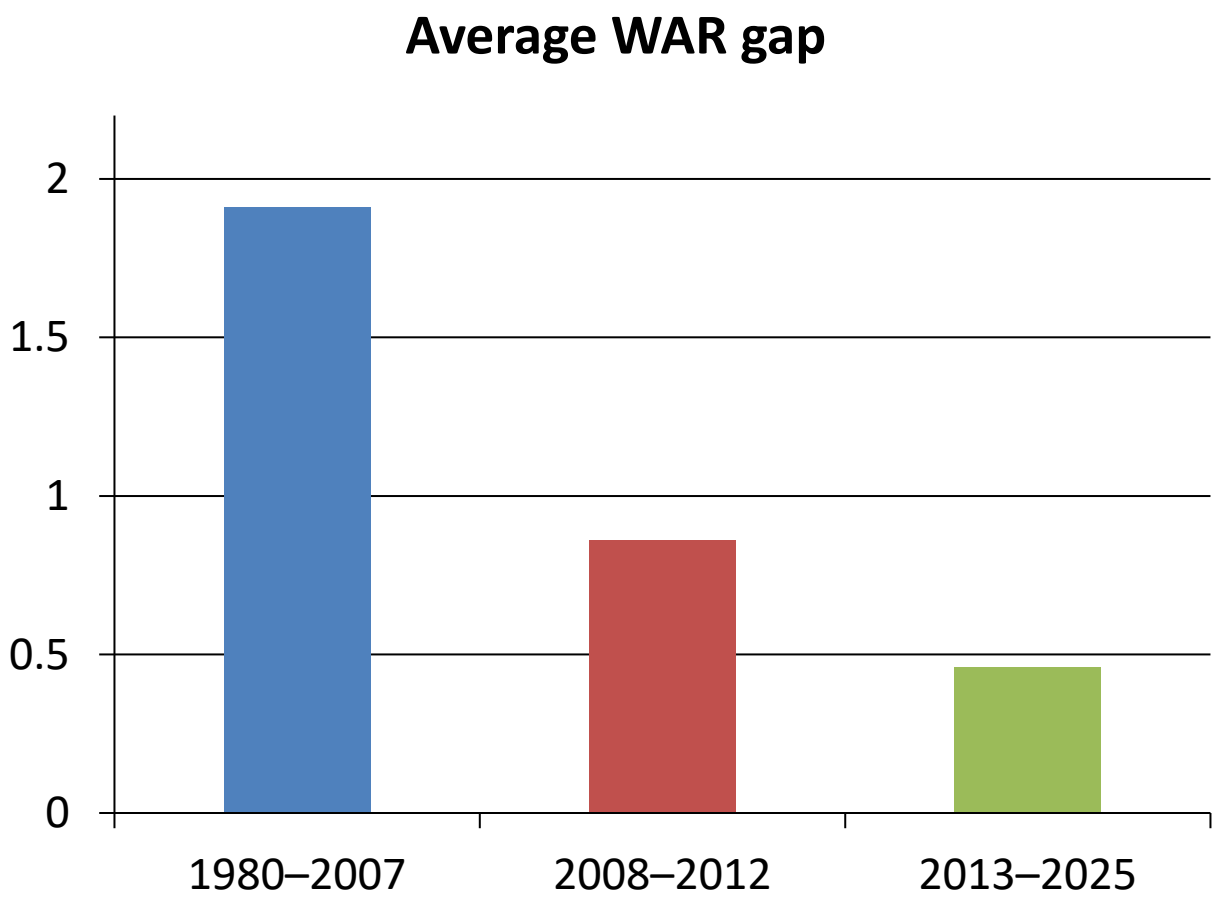
0.441 → 0.681

WAR / vote-share correlation

Pre-2008 to 2013–2025

- HR is nearly unchanged overall.
- RBI and BA show little long-run movement.
- OPS also rises in the modern era, suggesting a broader shift toward comprehensive performance measures.

MVP winners are much closer to the WAR leader



28.6%
1980–2007
MVP had highest WAR

58.3%
2013–2025
MVP had highest WAR

- Average MVP-to-highest-WAR gap fell from 1.91 WAR to 0.46 WAR.
- Modern voters do not always select the WAR leader, but their winner is usually much closer in WAR.

Historical races show how large the gaps once were

Race	MVP winner	WAR	Highest-WAR vote-getter	WAR	Gap
1996 AL	Juan González	3.8	Ken Griffey Jr.	9.7	5.9
1987 NL	Andre Dawson	4.0	Tony Gwynn	8.6	4.6
1998 AL	Juan González	4.9	Alex Rodriguez	8.5	3.6
2012 AL	Miguel Cabrera	7.1	Mike Trout	10.5	3.4

- All 15 largest WAR gaps in the current analysis occurred by 2012.
- 2012 is a notable outlier: Miguel Cabrera won the Triple Crown, an exceptionally rare achievement that provided important context surrounding the MVP vote.

Preliminary conclusion and next steps

What the data suggests

- MVP voting has become substantially more aligned with WAR.
- The strongest shift appears after the early 2010s.
- Traditional stats such as HR, RBI, and BA do not show a comparable increase.
- These patterns show association, not proof that WAR caused the change.

Next steps

- Repeat key analyses using position players only.
- Test whether era differences are statistically significant.
- Use full league WAR leaderboards, not only MVP vote-getters.
- Add historical context on when WAR became prominent in MVP discussion.